introduced rules for accumulation and consolidated the concentration of energy and finance sectors into the hands of a few wealthy bosses. He also exerted a certain level of state control over investors in order to buttress consumption and investment. This included the imprisonment of several millionaires.

This new vertical political power is based on fraud and the persecution of the opposition, but it has, nonetheless, gained several electoral victories. The flow of stolen votes is used to reinforce the political submission of a working class which has been orphaned from its traditions and practices of self-organisation. The legacy of many decades of bureaucratic totalitarianism continues to obstruct the formation of unions and left-wing groups, despite enormous social inequality and growing disillusionment with capitalism.[11]

Against this background of popular passivity and demoralisation, Putin has recreated a nationalist ideology which exalts provincial leaders and revives the old traditions of Slavic supremacy. He is trying to rebuild Russia's role as a sub-imperialist power over the entire area of the old Czarist Empire. Massacres of Chechens served as a point of departure for these efforts. In these, Russia could count on the implicit support of the West which was perpetrating similar crimes in the struggle against the 'terrorist enemy'. But this complicity did not attenuate the growing tension between Russia and US imperialism, which attempted to take advantage of the collapse of the USSR to exterminate its old rival. The US ringed Russia with NATO missiles in order to force the liquidation of the great Soviet arsenal.

Putin understood that disarmament would make forging a sufficiently solid capitalist system impossible, so he initiated a defensive plan to reconstruct Russia's military power. He intervened in Georgia, deployed troops into Central Asia, intervened in the negotiations with Syria, and annexed the Crimea in a coup against the Ukraine. These actions consolidated a state autonomy which the big capitalists needed in order to secure their investments. These sectors divided their sympathies between the United States and Europe, while they amassed fortunes in Berlin, London or New York. Today, the elite rely on a powerful Soviet tradition of intervening in global affairs and they leverage diplomacy in order to bolster business.

Russia has recovered this space because it maintains an enormous military structure, which is not under the collective supervision of imperialism. This military gravitas, and not its economic expansion, explains Russia's international resurgence. Yet the global crisis affected it more than other emerging economies and it has not rebuilt its previous industrial structure, relying heavily instead on gas and petroleum exports.